DARUMA DRAMA

Fall seven times, stand up eight.



3–5 players | 10+ | 30–40 min

Knock a Daruma doll over and it rolls back up. In Daruma Drama, every trick you lose leaves a toppled doll in front of you, and the oldest one becomes your own trump. Win a trick and you stand back up, banking every doll that fell.

COMPONENTS



Red hawk | Gold phoenix | Green sparrow | Blue owl | Purple crane

- **55 Daruma cards**: five colours, numbered 1 to 11. The number and the colour's bird are in all four corners, so a card lying sideways can still be read.
- **5 player aids** and **1 score pad**. You also need a pencil.

HOW IT WORKS

Daruma Drama is a must-follow trick-taking game with a twist:

- Lose a trick and the card you played stays in front of you, lying sideways: it has **fallen**.
- Your **oldest fallen card is your trump**.
- Win a trick and you **rise**: every fallen card scores 1 point.

Play one hand per player. The highest total wins.

YOUR FALL LINE



← Trump: Green

The cards lying sideways in front of you are your **fall line**, in the order they fell, oldest on the left.

The **leftmost card is your trump**. Its colour is a trump for you, and for nobody else. With an empty fall line, you have no trump.

This player's trump is Green. A win now scores 3.

SETUP

Before the first hand

1. Give each player a **player aid**.
2. Write each player's name on the **score pad**.
3. The player who most recently fell over is the first **dealer**.

At the start of every hand

4. **Deal.** Shuffle all 55 cards. Deal 11 each (9 with 5 players). Put the rest aside, face down and unseen.
5. **First fall.** Everyone chooses a card from their hand. All at once, lay it face up and sideways in front of you. It starts your fall line and is your first trump.
6. Leave room in the middle for a **discard pile**, and in front of you for your **score pile**.
7. The player to the dealer's left **leads the first trick**.

Players	Deal each	Tricks a hand	Hands
3	11	10	3
4	11	10	4
5	9	8	5

EXAMPLE: THE FIRST FALL



Anna lays the **Purple 4** sideways. Her trump is now Purple.

PLAYING A TRICK

The leader plays any card. Then, clockwise, everyone else plays one card.

1. Follow

If you have a card of the **led colour**, you must play one.

2. Trump

If you can't follow, play any card. If it matches **your trump**, it is a trump. Any other colour can't win.

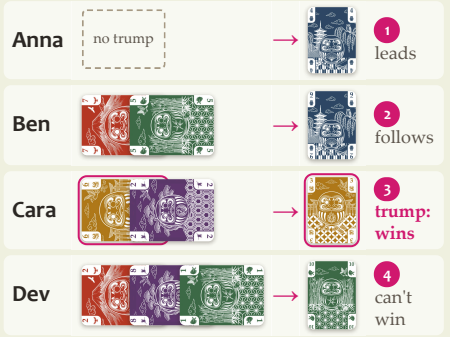
3. Win

The **highest trump** wins. If nobody trumped, the **highest card of the led colour** wins. Equal trumps: the one played first wins.

TRUMPS ARE PERSONAL

- Your trump counts for you alone. If yours is Gold, anyone else's Gold card is just a Gold card.
- You only trump when you can't follow. A card of the led colour is **never** a trump, even the leader's, even if it is the player's trump colour.
- Only the leftmost fallen card counts.
- Fall lines change only after the trick, so every trump stays the same during it.

EXAMPLE: WHO WINS THE TRICK



1. Anna leads the **Blue 4**.
2. Ben has Blue, so he must follow: **Blue 9**.
3. Cara has no Blue. Her trump is Gold, so her **Gold 3** is a trump.
4. Dev has no Blue and no Red (his trump). His **Green 10** can't win.

Cara wins with the only trump, though it is the lowest card.

AFTER THE TRICK

The losers fall and the winner rises, all at the same time.

The losers fall

Each loser lays the card they played **sideways at the right-hand end** of their fall line.

Knocked off

A fall line holds **at most 3 cards**. If a 4th falls, the leftmost card is knocked off onto the discard pile. The next card becomes your trump.

The winner rises

The winner puts **every card in their fall line** face down on their **score pile**: 1 point each. The winning card goes on the discard pile. The winner now has **no trump** until they next lose.

The next trick

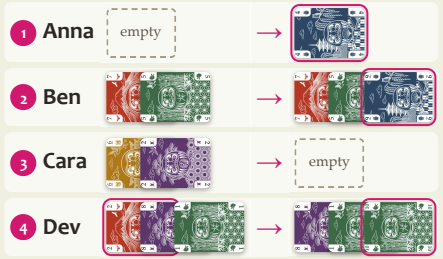
The winner leads.

RISING WITH NOTHING

Win with an empty fall line and you still lead next, but you score nothing.

EXAMPLE: AFTER THE TRICK

Cara won the trick in the last example.



1 Anna's Blue 4 falls. Her trump is now **Blue**.

2 Ben's Blue 9 falls on the right. His line is full; his trump is still Red.

3 Cara rises: Gold 6 and Purple 2 go to her score pile, **2 points**. Her Gold 3 is discarded. She has no trump and leads next.

4 Dev's Green 10 is a 4th card, so his Red 2 is knocked off. His trump is now **Purple**.

EXAMPLE: EQUAL TRUMPS



Next trick. Cara leads the **Gold 2**; Dev follows with the **Gold 11**. Anna and Ben have no Gold. Anna's **Blue 8** and Ben's **Red 8** are both trumps, and both beat the Gold 11.

They are equal, and Anna played first: **Anna wins** and banks her Blue 4 (1 point). Ben's Red 8 falls; his line was full, so his Red 7 is knocked off and his trump is now Green.

END OF A HAND

The hand ends when everyone has played every card.

1. **Lost falls.** Cards still in fall lines score nothing. Discard them.
2. **Score.** Count your score pile and write it on the score pad.
3. **Next hand.** Gather all 55 cards. The deal passes to the left. Start again at Setup, step 4.

END OF THE GAME

After **every player has dealt once**, add up the scores. The **highest total wins**.

Ties: the tied player whose last score pile holds the **most different colours** wins. Still tied? Share the win. So keep your last score pile until any tie is settled.

EXAMPLE: FINAL SCORES

	Anna	Ben	Cara	Dev
1	6	4	5	3
2	3	7	4	6
3	5	5	6	4
4	6	3	5	5
Total	20	19	20	18

Anna and Cara tie on 20. Anna's last score pile has 6 cards in 4 colours; Cara's has 5 cards in all 5 colours. **Cara wins.**

VARIANT: NO SCORE PAD

Play with the cards alone. All the rules apply, except:

- **Score piles stay out.** Keep yours face down in front of you all game.
- **Shuffle the rest:** discards, fall-line cards and unused cards.
- **Deal what you can:** the same number each, as many as possible, up to 11.
- **Game end:** if the cards can't give everyone at least 4, the game ends. Most cards in your score pile wins.

EXAMPLE: DEALING WHAT YOU CAN

Four players bank 6, 4, 5 and 3 cards in the first hand: 18 in all. The other 37 cards deal 9 each, with 1 left over.

Later, 14 cards are left: only 3 each. The game ends.

ABOUT DARUMA

Daruma dolls are modelled on Bodhidharma, the monk said to have brought Zen Buddhism to China. A new Daruma's eyes are blank: paint in one when you set a goal, the other when you reach it. Each colour is a wish: red for luck, gold for fortune, green for health, blue for learning, purple for long life. Nana korobi ya oki: fall seven times, stand up eight.

Game design: Dean Morris · Wombat Game Factory
Rule book v4 · 01/11/2026 · Prototype art